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OPERATION HORNET

At the Cafe de Flore on Boulevard Saint-Germain, Paris, in November 1984, Sanjeev Jindal was lost in thought. In India, the funeral procession of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi was underway and her son Rajiv Gandhi was about to take charge of the Congress party. The French president, Laurent Fabius, had flown to New Delhi to attend the funeral. As the tourists and locals around him discussed Ernest Hemingway and Albert Camus, Jindal thought about his recent trip to London where he had met his recruit, Clarke Lee, a R&AW informer primarily concerned with picking up intelligence on anti-India elements, especially Pakistanis like Abdul Khan who sheltered extremists.

Reading Clarke's report on the night of 3 November, Jindal was filled with anguish and rage. Could he help take down anti-India networks operating in Europe despite the sharp division between politicians and intelligence officers regarding covert operations abroad?

Since 1982, Khan had invited Pakistani intelligence officers, Indian fugitives and some local politicians to his Newham house in London. Among the reports sent by Clarke, there was a copy ofa coded memo dated 9 December 1983, warning that Khan had had several rounds of meetings with an Indian recruited by the ISI which meant that they must be plotting something sinister against India. Jindal remembered forwarding a polished report to New Delhi in a diplomatic pouch, but thanks to the lax analysts back home, he had never received a response. This was a classic example of the uneasy